

Build better *prompts*

The best answers start with the right kind of question. This guide shows the prompts that work for each kind, how to sharpen the ones that need it, and the habits that get you a strong answer the first time.

STEP 1

Pick the kind of question

You never pick a tool. Your AI tool does that for you. What you choose is the kind of question, and that decides where the answer comes from. Claude is shown as the example; other AI tools work the same way.

1 One account or deal

You're asking about one company or one deal.



RUNS IN · YOUR AI TOOL

COVERS · LAST 30 DAYS

2 A list

You want several deals or accounts that match a filter.



RUNS IN · YOUR AI TOOL

FILTERS · OWNER, CLOSE DATE, ENGAGEMENT

3 Backstory's assistant

You want the bigger picture, or context older than 30 days.



RUNS IN · BACKSTORY'S ASSISTANT

START WITH · "ASK BACKSTORY'S ASSISTANT"

✓ **Ask it like this.** Tested prompts. Swap in your account.

✍ **Sharpen it.** Works well with one extra step.

↪ **Ask this instead.** A better route to the same answer.

1 One account or deal

Prep, catch up, risks, people and next steps. Use the full company name.

✓ ASK IT LIKE THIS

- "Help me prep for my call with Halden Freight." REP
- "Catch me up on Halden Freight." REP · AM/CSM
- "Any risks on the Halden Freight renewal deal?" REP · MGR
- "What's Backstory flagging on the Halden Freight renewal deal?" MGR
- "What did we agree to do for Halden Freight, and who's on the hook?" AM/CSM
- "Using Backstory, who have we been talking to at Halden Freight in the last 30 days, and when?" AM/CSM · REP
- "Summarize the last month with Vantage Retail." REP · AM/CSM

✍ SHARPEN IT

Drafting a follow-up email

Ask for the agreed next steps first, then draft. Check owners and dates before you send.

Comparing two accounts

Ask for a side-by-side and make the call yourself.

Similar past deals

Treat matches as examples. You may get a different set each time.

News and exec moves

Public companies only, from filings and earnings. Check the date before you repeat it.

↪ ASK THIS INSTEAD

- "What changed this week?" → "What's the latest on the Halden Freight renewal deal?"
- Tomorrow's meetings or the latest email → Add your calendar or email connector to the same AI tool.

OVERLEAF Lists and Backstory's assistant

see what's coming know what to do

2 A list

Build it from four filters. Backstory tells you how it read the question before it pulls the list.

THE FOUR FILTERS THAT WORK

"Which of my team's deals closing this quarter have engagement under 50?"

Whose	Close date	Engagement	Calendar ahead
My deals, my team's, or a named rep's	Closing this quarter	Under 50 for deals, under 30 for accounts	Nothing booked in the next 30 days

✓ ASK IT LIKE THIS

- "Using Backstory, what deals do I have closing this quarter?" REP
- "What deals does my team have closing this quarter?" MGR · VP
- "Which of my team's deals closing this quarter have engagement under 50?" MGR · VP
- "Which of my team's accounts have engagement under 30?" AM/CSM · VP
- "What deals does Priya Shah have closing this quarter? Give me the risks and next steps on each." MGR
- "Which of Priya Shah's deals have nothing on the calendar in the next 30 days?" MGR

✍ SHARPEN IT

"My" and "biggest" lists

Read how Backstory understood the list before you say yes: your deals, the right window, highest first.

↪ ASK THIS INSTEAD

- "No meeting in the last 60 days" → "...nothing on the calendar in the next 30 days"
- Renewals or commit in a list → List deals closing this quarter, then ask about the risks on each.
- "Late-stage" or "by owner" → Stick to the four filters, then sort the list yourself.
- Ranking by risk or predicting closes → Pull a list, then ask about the risks on each deal that matters.
- Forecast changes or commit category → Open Backstory Forecasting in the app.

3 Backstory's assistant

Big-picture themes and context older than 30 days. Start with "Ask Backstory's assistant" so your AI tool passes it on.

HOW FAR BACK EACH KIND REACHES

Questions 1 and 2

Backstory's assistant

90 days ago

60

Last 30 days · Today

✓ ASK IT LIKE THIS

- "Ask Backstory's assistant what the big themes have been with Halden Freight over the last 90 days." VP
- **Lead with the prefix.** Without it, your AI tool answers from the last 30 days.
- **Ask for themes over a window.** Themes across 90 days come back steady.
- **Name the account in full.** Same rule as every other question.

✍ SHARPEN IT

"Since July," "in June," taking over an account

Most reliable for the last 30 days. Ask for themes beyond that, then check key dates against your CRM.

Renewal amounts and dates

Check figures from the assistant against the deal record before you share them.

↪ ASK THIS INSTEAD

- Long history with no prefix → Start with "Ask Backstory's assistant"
- A single email or meeting from months back → Ask for the themes over that period instead.

OVERLEAF Rewrites, habits and shortcuts

see what's coming know what to do

PUT IT TOGETHER

Three quick rewrites

Each one moves a vague ask into the right kind of question.

VAGUE

"How's Halden going?"

SHARP

"Catch me up on Halden Freight."

WHAT CHANGED

Full company name · **Kind 1**

"Which of Priya's deals went quiet in the last 60 days?"

"Which of Priya Shah's deals have nothing on the calendar in the next 30 days?"

Looks ahead, not back · **Kind 2**

"What's happened with Halden Freight since July?"

"Ask Backstory's assistant what the big themes have been with Halden Freight over the last 90 days."

Prefix plus a window · **Kind 3**

HABITS

Seven habits for a strong first answer

01

Check the company name in the first answer

Short names can match the wrong account.

02

Start a new chat for each new question

Long chats are more likely to make mistakes.

03

Read how Backstory understood a list

Your deals, the right window, highest first.

04

Remember answers cover the last 30 days

Say so when you share.

05

For anything older, start with "Ask Backstory's assistant"

06

A thin answer isn't "nothing happened"

The activity may not have been captured.

07

Check the assistant's figures against the deal

Especially renewal amounts and dates.

SHORTCUT

Build these into a skill once and every answer follows them.

SHORTCUTS

When you land on an answer you like, *turn it into a skill*

A skill saves the prompt, the steps and the layout, so you get the same result every time and keep improving it.



Skills, not go-to prompts

A meeting-prep skill runs when you name a company.



Standing instructions

Full company name. Every number gets its time window.



Calendar and email

Add both connectors so one ask covers the week.



Gaps show as gaps

Mark fields "not available from Backstory."



Test before trusting

Three real asks, one badly worded on purpose.

REACH FOR ONE

Before customer calls

Writing follow-ups

Planning your week

Taking over an account

Name the account. Pick the kind. *Check the reading.*

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Halden Freight, Vantage Retail and Priya Shah are mock examples.